UNITED COLOURS OF INDIA The Indian National Democratic Inclusive Alliance comes together after the general election results, Jun. 5, 2024

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census, a plank then ally Nitish Kumar delivered on in his own state of Bihar by September 2023.

But just when everything seemed to be going right for the alliance, Nitish Kumar decided to execute a U-turn. The JD(U) veteran returned to the National Democratic Alliance in January 2024 after his efforts to marshal I.N.D.I.A.'s disparate ranks ran aground on the Congress's reluctance to cede him the lead role. Even so, I.N.D.I.A. managed a 234-seat tally in the 2024 parliamentary polls, pausing, if not halting, the BJP juggernaut.

The optimism proved short-lived, as regional satraps within the alliance began losing their citadels. Uddhav Thackeray, with his rump Shiv Sena, and Sharad Pawar, with the diminished Nationalist Congress Party, watched Maharashtra slip from their grasp in November 2024. This was followed by the spectacular eclipse of Arvind Kejriwal and his Aam Aadmi Party in the national capital this February, and then the NDA slaying the RJD in Bihar in November. With the BJP breathing down her neck, it is now Mamata's turn to guard her fortress. If Bengal falls, so will the experiment called I.N.D.I.A. ■



▲ *Jan. 30, 2023*



▲ *Feb. 12, 2024*

DEFYING EXPECTATIONS

Just when it seemed all but written off, the INDIA bloc sprung a surprise in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Whether Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra contributed to that outcome remains an open question